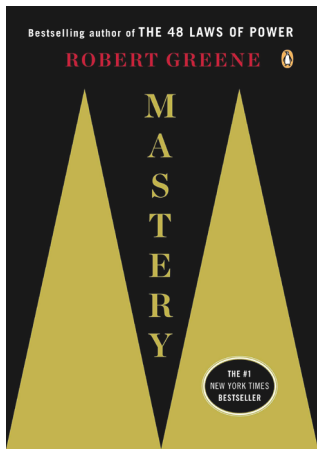




MASTERY

ROBERT GREENE



The Big “So What”

In this book, Greene examines the lives of exceptional historical figures like Charles Darwin and Leonardo Da Vinci to uncover how they become widely-admired Masters. **Using the strategies in this book, you too can become a high achiever and attain mastery in your desired field(s).**



Introduction



Mastery is the sensation that you're in full control of yourself, your environment and reality. **As a master, you can enjoy both money and fulfillment doing what you naturally love.**



Each of us is born with the potential for greatness.

- Your brain is malleable, i.e. it changes depending on how you use it. So, your actions literally shape your brain to affect your abilities and your life.
- Today, we have more freedom of choice and access to knowledge than past generations. With the right beliefs, attitude and approach, anyone can achieve greatness.



Based on extensive research on neuro/cognitive sciences and various Masters' biographies, Greene discovered that mastery can be nurtured systematically in 3 phases:

- Apprenticeship: This is when you learn the basics of a certain field.

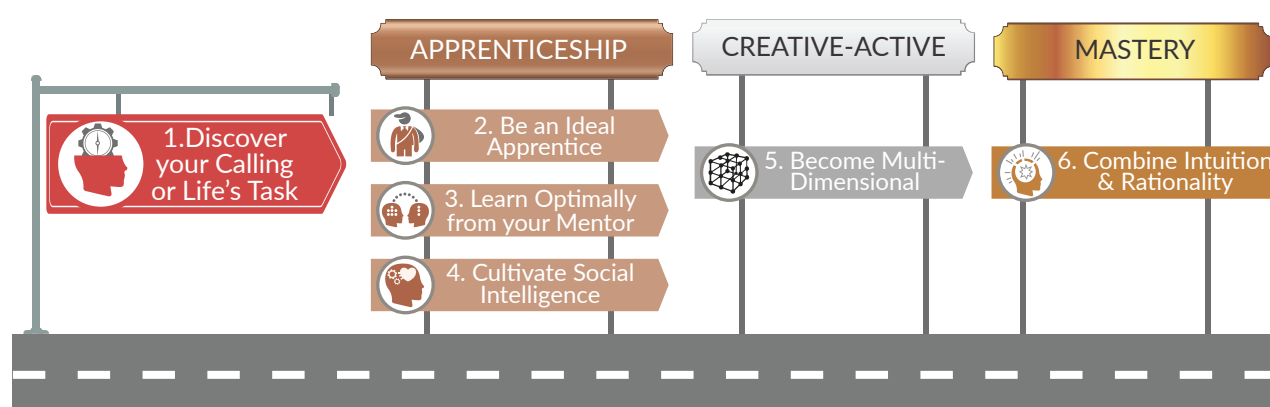
KEY QUOTES

“Everyone holds his fortune in his own hands, like a sculptor the raw material he will fashion into a figure.”
—Johann Wolfgang von Goethe

“Our dominance, our mastery does not stem from our hands but from... fashioning the mind into the most powerful instrument known in nature.”

- Creative-active: With immersion and practice, you deepen your understanding of the field and start to experiment with your own methods.
- Mastery: You have such high levels of focus, knowledge and experience that you can see the full picture and bend/change the rules to achieve spectacular results. It typically takes at least 10,000 hours of intense practice, or about 20 years to attain the required combination of skills, knowledge, and intuition.

In this summary, we'll present the strategies and tips for the 3 phases of Mastery in 6 parts.



Part 1: Find Your Calling or Life's Task



All of us have an internal force that nudges us toward our calling or Life's Task. As a child, you were intuitively drawn to certain topics or activities. Yet, as you mature, this force may be muted due to social pressures—you end up working for money or for others' approval and get disconnected from your true identity.



Look inward and reconnect with your natural inclinations.

- Find your vocation or the work that's deeply connected to who you are. When you find your ideal vocation, it feels "right" and you find yourself learning much faster with a sense of child-like wonder.
- When you align your efforts with your passions, it's easier to sustain the years of hard work required on the path to mastery.

KEY QUOTES

"Intuitive powers at the mastery level are a mix of the instinctive and the rational, the conscious and the unconscious, the human and the animal."

"You possess a kind of inner force that seeks to guide you toward your Life's Task—what you are meant to accomplish in the time that you have to live."

"Your vocation is more than the work that you do. It is intimately connected to the deepest part of your being and is a manifestation of the intense diversity in nature and within human culture."



5 Strategies to Discover Your Life's Task



Primal Inclination Strategy: Think back on what fascinated you as a child: did you respond profoundly to an object, feel empowered by certain activities, feel fascinated by certain cultural aspects, or feel inspired by a specific Master? Consider the things that still bring out a sense of child-like wonder, visceral feelings and deep connection in you. Leonardo Da Vinci spent hours as a child contemplating nature and drawing things in painstaking detail. This continued into his adulthood, where he was always trying uncover the essence of life by studying and creating things.



Darwinian Strategy: Don't follow a conventional career path and compete in a crowded space. Find the perfect niche that you can dominate using these 2 approaches:

- Move in a broad direction, then keep narrowing your path until you reach a specialized, unoccupied niche. As a child, V. S. Ramachandran was obsessed with science books and seashells. He went on to research human anatomical abnormalities, optical illusions and blind spots, before moving into visual psychology. He knew he'd found his niche (anomalous neurological disorders) when he stopped feeling restless or out of place for the first time in his life.
- Develop expertise in multiple areas then combine them in a unique way. Yoky Matsuoka was an accomplished tennis player who left her sporting career to study electrical engineering, then artificial intelligence in robots. She eventually combined her interests/expertise to create a new field called neurobotics.



Rebellion Strategy: Actively rebel against the forces that lead you toward the wrong career (e.g. parental influence, fame, money). In his early music career, Mozart's potential was limited by his father's tight control. After Mozart reached adulthood, he finally broke free to pursue his own path. This alienated him from his father, but led to the creation of his most famous masterpieces today.

KEY QUOTES

"In order to master a field, you must love the subject and feel a profound connection to it. Your interest must transcend the field itself and border on the religious."

"Ultimately you create a field that is uniquely your own."

"Your true self...comes from deep within you...It exists for a purpose, and it is your Life's Task to bring it to fruition."

"It is a healthy part of your development to...establish your own identity. Let your sense of rebellion fill you with energy and purpose."



Adaptation Strategy: Don't be trapped by your past choices. If something isn't working for you, let it go and find creative ways to adapt/apply your existing skills and experience. After Freddie Roach was forced to retire as a championship boxer, he felt disgruntled and became a telemarketer. Later, he realized that his real passion wasn't for boxing, but for competitive sports and strategies. He started to train other boxers using novel training methods and went on to become the most successful trainer of his generation.



Life-or-Death Strategy: Even if you've deviated from the right path, it's never too late to get back on track. Let your failures and weaknesses turn you from the wrong paths, and focus on becoming excellent at the things that you're good at.

- After a series of setbacks, Buckminster Fuller was so disillusioned that he attempted suicide. At the last moment, he had an epiphany. He realized that his "mistakes" were merely the Universe's way of directing him in a better direction. He followed his inner voice and conceived many game-changing inventions and ideas.
- Temple Grandin was born with autism and struggled with many things. She focused on the 2 things she was good at—interacting with animals and building things with her hands—and found her niche as a specialist on animals and autism.



Part 2: Be an Ideal Apprentice



All Masters go through a transformative phase in their lives, like how a butterfly emerges from its chrysalis. This typically involves a self-directed apprenticeship that lasts 5-10 years.

- Theoretical knowledge from your formal education isn't enough. You need a practical education to learn how the world truly works, develop practical skills and discipline, and train yourself to think independently.
- During the apprenticeship phase, your goal is not to seek money or status, but to transform your mind and character. Choose a role that will give you the greatest

KEY QUOTES

"Your Life's Task is a living, breathing organism."

"In the end, the money and success that truly last come not to those who focus on such things as goals, but rather to those who focus on mastery and fulfilling their Life's Task."

*"One can have no smaller or greater mastery than mastery of oneself."
– Leonardo da Vinci*

"See your apprenticeship as a kind of journey in which you will transform yourself, rather than as a drab indoctrination into the work world."

growth opportunities. Charles Darwin spent almost 5 years on a ship collecting life and mineral specimens. The voyage transformed him from a reluctant student to a committed, enthusiastic naturalist. The insights from those months of real-world study sparked his theory of evolution, which he then devoted his life to validating.



The 3 Modes of Apprenticeship

Learn how to learn, so you can conquer any field.



Passive mode: observe deeply. Every field involves centuries of accumulated knowledge, rules and relationships. Drop your preconceptions, so you can absorb what's really going on.

- Pay close attention to (i) how things are done (including explicit/hidden rules and procedures), and (ii) the power dynamics (including the relationships, communications and control structures). These help you to navigate the environment, develop observation and analytical skills, and build the habit of diagnosing a situation before jumping into action.



Practice mode: develop skills. In the Middle Ages, young people spent 7 years to learn their craft as apprentices, observing and imitating their masters, then repeatedly practicing the skills.

- Build 1 new skill at a time. Don't multi-task.
- Persist with focused, repeated practice. Prolonged and consistent practice changes your brain neurologically, so the skills become hard-wired. Don't jump from task to task: 2-3 hours of focused work is much better than 8 hours of distracted work.
- Once you can do an action automatically, step back to assess how to improve. Observe yourself from a distance, get feedback from others and measure your progress.
- You'll experience a cycle of accelerated returns: what used to be hard will get progressively easier and more pleasurable. You will also be gradually transformed.

KEY QUOTES

"The ability to observe any unfamiliar environment will become a critical lifelong skill."

"Concentrated practice over time cannot fail but produce results."

The pain and boredom we experience in the initial stage of learning a skill toughens our minds, much like physical exercise.

"You cannot make anything worthwhile in this world unless you have first developed and transformed yourself."



Action mode: experiment with new approaches. Force yourself to start experimenting *before* you think you're ready. In so doing, you'll know where you stand, get feedback to improve, gain a thicker skin, and learn to manage your ego. Use failures and criticism as fuel to improve yourself. This prepares you for the next phase where you must deliver results under constant scrutiny.



8 Strategies for a Successful Apprenticeship



Focus on learning, not money. If you develop the desired skills, you'll eventually earn money. But if you focus on money, you may end up with a career you dislike. Look for learning opportunities with hands-on work and great mentors. Offer to work for free so people may be more willing to teach you their trade secrets.



Keep pushing your boundaries. Interact with as many different people and ideas as possible to expand your mind. Whenever you start to feel comfortable, shake things up and seek new challenges.



Let go of your ego or sense of superiority. Return to a beginner's mind—have a child-like curiosity and openness, and be willing to depend on those who can teach you.



Achieving mastery takes time, and you'll likely feel frustrated or insecure along the way. Be patient and trust the process. If you keep working and learning, you will eventually make it.



Embrace discomfort and pain instead of avoiding them. Critique your own work ruthlessly. Push your focus, creativity etc. beyond your perceived limits.



Treat your failures as lessons—use them to uncover what you must change/improve to succeed in future.



Go beyond appearances (how things *seem* to be) to learn how things really work. Learn all the necessary skills in your field, including the “whats” (visible outcomes) and the “hows” (hidden secrets, underlying anatomy and connections that affect how things move and change).

KEY QUOTES

“What is important when you are young...is to train yourself to get by with little money and make the most of your youthful energy.”

“Be relentless in your pursuit for expansion...Soon, ideas and opportunities will come to you and your apprenticeship will naturally complete itself.”

“When it comes to mastering a skill, time is the magic ingredient.”

“Repeated failure will toughen your spirit and show you with absolute clarity how things must be done.”



Don't follow a fixed career path. Grow through trial and error, exploring different paths connected to your deepest interests and learning as many related skillsets as possible. Ideally, start a broad apprenticeship when you're young to expand your future options.



Part 3: Learn Optimally from Your Mentor



Life is short, so don't waste time learning without guidance. A good mentor can greatly accelerate your apprenticeship.

- Michael Faraday was the son of a blacksmith who learned about science through books and lectures. But he only developed real scientific know-how after he became an assistant to prominent chemist Humphry Davy. For years, Faraday soaked up Davy's knowledge while developing his own insights. He went on to develop theories that revolutionized 20th Century science and far outshone his former-mentor.
- You can self-learn using generic information from books/courses. However, good mentors speed up the learning process drastically by tailoring the insights and feedback specifically for you.
- It's best to have 1 mentor at a time. But if you can't find a perfect mentor, find various mentors to fill different gaps.



Face-to-face interaction is crucial for learning the nuances behind a craft. Masters are busy, so you'll have to make the most of whatever time you get with them.

- To attract potential mentors, first develop yourself—demonstrate work ethics, organizational skills and an enthusiasm for learning. Be prepared to embrace menial work and add value to the Masters in whatever way you can.
- A strong mentor-protégé relationship requires mutual emotional investment—the mentor feels vested in your success, while you admire the mentor as a role model. Be humble, submit yourself fully and absorb all you can as an apprentice.

KEY QUOTES

"We must constantly ask the questions – how do things work, how do decisions get made, how does the group interact?"

"The right mentors know where to focus your attention and how to challenge you. Their knowledge and experience become yours."

"Mentors do not give you a shortcut, but they streamline the process."

"You want person-to-person access, however you can get it."

 On the path to mastery, each mentor is only a stepping-stone to the next level. Your goal is to surpass your masters. Once you've internalized what they have to offer, move on without guilt. Don't stay in their shadows.



4 Strategies to Optimize the Relationship with Your Mentor

Build a productive emotional connection so your mentor is more likely to reveal trade secrets that're not usually shared with others.



Choose a mentor who suits your needs and limitations, including (i) the right skills and knowledge for your goals, and (ii) the right fit for your calling and learning style. You want someone to nurture your unique traits, not squash them. Sigmund Freud was a mentor to Carl Jung for 5 years, until Jung decided he could no longer accept Freud's dictatorial style. Still, the mentorship shaped Jung's self-identity and theories, without which he couldn't have started his own branch of psychoanalysis.



Embrace tough love from your mentor. A good mentor points out the harsh truths and puts you through the necessary ordeals, so you become grounded in reality and toughened to overcome challenges.



Don't just copy your mentors. Learn to think independently and adapt their styles/ideas to differentiate yourself. Piano maestro Glenn Gould spent 8 years learning from Alberto Guerrero before striking out on his own. By infusing Guerrero's teachings with his own spirit and creativity, he created a style that encompassed Guerrero's essence but was even greater.



As an apprentice gains mastery, he may disagree with the mentor and resent the latter's authority, while the mentor may try to suppress perceived threats or challenges to his authority. Seek to create a two-way dynamic in your relationship. Boxing coach Freddie Roach transformed Manny Pacquiao into a top boxer. Pacquiao never tired of Roach's coaching, while Roach used Pacquiao's improvisation and feedback to hone his own coaching

KEY QUOTES

"Your goal is always to surpass your mentors in mastery and brilliance."

"You must get the sharpest dose of reality that is possible from your mentor. You must go in search of it and welcome it."

*"Poor is the apprentice who does not surpass his Master."
– Leonardo da Vinci*

"Once a back-and-forth dynamic is sparked, the relationship has almost limitless potential for learning and absorbing power."

techniques. Receive instructions respectfully but occasionally push back to clarify what you need, adapt some of the ideas or offer feedback on their instruction.



Part 4: Cultivate Social Intelligence



Social intelligence is the ability to see people as they are, instead of how we imagine them to be. It improves your relationships and quality of thinking. On the other hand, social naivety leads to mistakes, conflict and confusion, leaving you with little time/energy for mastery.

- Understand the reasons behind others' behavior so you can manage each person or situation like playing a game of chess. Benjamin Franklin was famous for his social intelligence. To get the French's support in the War of Independence, he shed his celibate habits to adopt the French's lavish and wanton lifestyle. Many Americans criticized him, not realizing this was his key to winning the French's trust and brokering a vital military alliance.
- Accept human nature as it is. Everyone has a dark side (e.g. being manipulative, defensive or greedy). Don't get overly upset or cynical about people, nor try to change them.



Master human nature in 2 parts:

- Specific knowledge of human nature, i.e. the ability to read people and understand their character and viewpoints. Pay close attention to what they say/do over time, their non-verbal cues and their work/living spaces. Put yourself in their shoes to understand what they're going through.
- General knowledge about timeless patterns of human behavior. Learn to detect and avoid these 7 ugly aspects in all humans:
 - (i) *Envy* can lead people to block you. Be humble, display some weakness or insecurity, and don't make others feel stupid.
 - (ii) Every group requires some *conformity*. Blend in and don't voice your dissent openly, at least until you've established your position in the group.

KEY QUOTES

"To be truly charming and socially effective you have to understand people, and to understand them you have to get outside yourself and immerse your mind in their world."

"Better to accept...people as one accepts the thorns on a rose. Better to observe and accumulate knowledge on human nature, as one accumulates knowledge in the sciences."

"People will say all kinds of things about their motives and intentions...Their actions, however, say much more about their character."

- (iii) People may *rigidly* stick to what's familiar. Outwardly respect others' need for order but seek fresh ideas on your own.
- (iv) People will always act in their *self-interest*. When making a request, always appeal to what's in it for them.
- (v) People are *lazy* and prefer faster/easier paths to their goals. Don't let others steal your ideas/credit or pass you the hard work in the guise of collaboration.
- (vi) People often make *flighty*, irrational decisions. Focus on what others do, not what they say or promise.
- (vii) To counter *passive aggression*, avoid direct confrontations. Exit the conflict or use a subtle/indirect counter-attack.



4 Strategies for Developing Social Intelligence



Don't fight political maneuvering or resistance head on. Speak through your work—be efficient, involve others, embrace feedback, deliver results, and show you can advance the group's objectives.



People will judge you based on your appearance. Design personas that suit you (e.g. mysterious, imposing). Switch your personas to match your environment, like how a performer wears various masks.



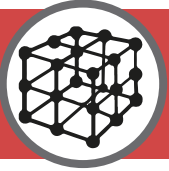
We're usually oblivious to our social flaws. Consider how others see you: get feedback and reflect on past conflicts to honestly assess how you may have contributed to the problems.



Don't waste your energy on fools who lack common sense, focus on the wrong things, or create trouble. Use them to remind yourself what not to do, or turn their foolishness to your advantage.

KEY QUOTES

"Think of the workplace as a kind of theater in which you are always wearing a mask."



Part 5: Become Multi-Dimensional (Creative-Active)



During childhood, our minds are totally open, we experience the world using all our senses and anything seems possible. Yet, as we grow up, we start to limit ourselves with rules and assumptions. Masters have a “Dimensional Mind” that combines a child-like spirit with focused, disciplined learning.

- There are 2 criteria for cultivating the Dimensional Mind: (i) deep knowledge of a subject and (ii) the ability to apply this knowledge in flexible, original ways. After Mozart broke free from his father’s strict control, he was able to create a totally new style of music by combining 20 years of musical experience with his inner voice and creativity.
- Learn the rules of a field during your apprenticeship without being limited by them. Challenge and reshape the rules you’ve learned. Keep expanding your skills, knowledge and experience by exploring new fields, making new connections and experimenting with new concepts.



3 Steps to Become Multi-Dimensional



Choose a creative task that’ll maximize your skills and knowledge.

- Pick a task you’re obsessed about and feel deeply connected to. For Mozart, it was composing opera music. For Edison, it was solving the electric light riddle. You’ll need the passion to sustain you through the hard work and setbacks.
- Ideally, pick something that triggers your sense of rebelliousness. Make sure you have the skills and knowledge to realistically pull it off, but be prepared to embrace uncertainty and discomfort



Use 5 creative strategies to continuously stretch your mind:

KEY QUOTES

“Masters...are simply people who manage to retain a sizeable portion of their childhood spirit despite the pressures and demands of adulthood.”

“As you emerge from your apprenticeship, you must become increasingly bold.”

“Think of yourself as an explorer. You cannot find anything new if you are unwilling to leave the shore.”

- “Negative capability” is the ability to embrace the unknown. Accept that you don’t know everything. Suspend your judgment, consider conflicting views, and see the world as it is instead of fitting things into your pre-conceptions. This opens your mind to creative alternatives.
- Allow for unexpected discoveries. Broaden your research to include diverse fields and examples that can disprove your theories. If you’re tensed, take a break or switch to a relaxing activity. A relaxed mind absorbs inputs better and makes more connections, which can lead to serendipity. You can also use random words, images or analogies/metaphors to jolt your brain into fresh ways of thinking.
- Alternate between real-world observations and mental speculations about what they mean. Repeatedly develop theories then test them in reality to grasp complex concepts beyond your limited human senses (e.g. electricity, evolution, gravity).
- Expand your perspective: (i) look at “what” and “how”, (ii) examine details in addition to the big picture (to see how the parts fit into the whole), (iii) examine anomalies (not just the norm) and (iv) look at what’s missing (not just what’s present).
- Don’t limit yourself to words. Humans naturally think in images, so use visuals and 3D models to crystallize your ideas. If possible, activate all your senses: use music, paintings, fragrances etc. to stimulate your brain.



Create the ideal conditions for a creative breakthrough. Masters set high standards and work with such intensity and urgency that it pushes their minds to new levels. Yet the solution often surfaces when/after they take a break. **Push yourself as hard as possible, then let go periodically when you feel strained or hit a creative block.**

- Set deadlines to force your brain to work at an unusually-high level of intensity. French mathematician Evariste Galois was about to enter a duel and knew he may die. He worked fervently on several complex math problems that had remained unsolved for a long time, and managed to complete most of them.

KEY QUOTES

“To negate the ego you must adopt a kind of humility toward knowledge.”

“Chance favors only the prepared mind.”
– Louis Pasteur

“Creative people are actually looking at what is hidden in plain sight, and not rushing to generalize and label.”

“Creativity is by its nature an act of boldness and rebellion.”

- When you feel stuck, take a break. The solution may just come to you after that. Albert Einstein spent 10 years studying general relativity and decided one night to give up. After a night's rest, he woke up with the solution.

 Beware of these 6 common emotional obstacles to creativity: complacency, conservatism, dependency on others, impatience, egotism and inflexibility.



9 Creative-Active Strategies



The Authentic Voice. Learn the basics and absorb a wide range of styles/techniques. Once these are hard-wired in your system, your mind is free to creatively combine and personalize them until you find your unique voice.



Look for “facts of great yield”. It's better to examine many facts that'll lead to 1 big discovery, than to succeed in many trivial ideas with minimal impact. Scan for anomalies or intriguing facts that could reveal a hidden truth with a huge impact (e.g. debunking a prevailing norm, or a discovery with unlimited applications). Dig deeply to uncover those truths.



Don't study just 1 part of a system. Assume all parts are closely intertwined. Take the time to examine the topic from different angles and study the complex interlinkages.



Develop the mechanical intelligence required for superb craftsmanship and long-term success. Personally test/use your creations so you can see/sense how the parts work together holistically. The Wright Brothers beat teams of well-funded engineers to build the world's 1st motor-operated airplane. Instead of using abstract plans and specialists for different parts, they figured out the mechanics of flight by testing many different theories and prototypes in real life.



Give time to your creative process. Initially, give yourself time to dream and explore, using powerful emotions to drive your ideas. Then, refine your ideas without being fixated on your initial vision.

KEY QUOTES

“What you want in the end is to internalize the voice of your Master so that you become both teacher and pupil.”

“Better to look into ten such facts, with only one yielding a great discovery, than to look into twenty ideas that bring success but have trivial implications.”

“The extreme paradox is that those who impress the most with their individuality...are the ones who first completely submerge their character in a long apprenticeship.”



If everyone follows established norms, the culture feels cluttered. When you go against convention to pursue an idea you feel strongly about, it's like creating an open field to plant and grow your idea. People will be drawn to that new space.



When you're stuck with technical details, zoom out to reconnect with a broad inspiring vision and free your mind to see new paths.



The creative process doesn't follow a straight line. Your breakthrough could very well come from a random event that connects everything you've learned over the years—a process known as "evolutionary hijack".



We tend to think in binary terms (e.g. good vs bad, pain vs pleasure) when things don't fit into neat categories. Remove those artificial constraints and consider how to blend opposites into third alternatives.



Part 6: Combine Intuition & Rationality (Mastery)



There's a higher form of intelligence that enables us to grasp the intangible and predict trends, much like a sixth sense. Masters often talk of seeing something "more". Chess master Bobby Fischer could see forces that predicts how a chess game would unfold. Albert Einstein had a mental image of how the universe worked that others couldn't conceive.



This intelligence is cultivated through years of intense and persistent immersion in a field. **You acquire such a thorough understanding of the intricacies in a field that you can combine the rational and intuitive to grasp the complex realities.**

- There's a limit to our rational, conscious minds. We can break down a complex system by studying its parts, e.g. trying to understand an animal by studying its anatomy and behaviors as separate parts. But we miss the unseen, complex forces behind how living organisms evolve, or how entire ecosystems or galaxies work.

KEY QUOTES

"Creativity and adaptability are inseparable."

"By delving into the chaotic and fluid zone below the level of consciousness where opposites meet, you will be surprised at the exciting and fertile ideas that will come bubbling up to the surface."

"The reasoning of Masters is guided by intuition; their intuition springs from intense rational focus. The two are fused."

- During their years of study, Masters absorb info, apply and internalize them to the point that they're deeply locked into their memory. They can perform their craft by reflex, which frees up their minds to make sub-conscious associations. Their minds keep expanding until they can grasp complex realities in their entirety.



It typically takes 15-20 years to develop your intuition in an area.

- Masters learn to pay attention to high-level intuitions and act upon them. Some lead nowhere while others produce great insights. With time, they can call up these intuitions more automatically and fuse them with their rational thoughts.
- You can't rush the process. Exercise self-control, trust the process, commit yourself to intense study and take one step at a time.



7 Strategies to Attain Mastery

Masters don't try to fit into a conventional mold. They follow their inner compass, even if it means facing others' ridicule and criticism.



Connect deeply with your environment: observe it closely and experience it both physically and viscerally. Become so highly attuned to your environment that you can sense changes before they occur. Caroline Islanders can navigate complex oceans without any maps or instruments—they use their brain's primal powers alone to navigate using star constellations and the sun's position.



Play to your strengths. Swim with the current, not against it. Albert Einstein disdained convention and traditional learning, but was great at using mental images to solve abstract puzzles. He boldly decided to work by himself, turning over novel ideas in his head and challenging prevailing norms to develop the Theory of Relativity.



When we're learning a new skill (e.g. driving a car or plane), we must consciously think of the steps, as if our mind and body are disjointed. With repeated practice, you can

KEY QUOTES

"We embrace the natural complexity of life, making the brain expand to the dimensions of reality instead of shrinking it to the narrowest of specializations."

"Mastery is not a function of genius or talent. It is a function of time and intense focus applied to a particular field of knowledge."

"If there is any instrument you must fall in love with and fetishize, it is the human brain—the most miraculous, awe-inspiring, information-processing tool devised in the known universe."

"Know your strengths and move with them."

achieve mind-body integration to operate seamlessly. If you keep mastering new skills, you'll have layers of information at your fingertips that can be called up easily.



Leonardo da Vinci spent decades to observe, contemplate and create elements of nature until he could express the very essence of life in his artwork. View your work as being alive—absorb the details until you can capture the life force as an intrinsic part of your work.

↶ ↷ Gain a bigger perspective, so you can think strategically beyond the present moment. Freddie Roach gained a holistic perspective of competitive boxing after years of experience as a boxer and apprentice trainer. He then helped his fighters to see the full picture of the fight and develop/practice holistic strategies.



To truly understand something, you must immerse yourself in it. If you research something from the outside, you unknowingly filter the data and analysis through your own assumptions. The only way to truly understand other people or cultures is to learn from the inside by experiencing their beliefs, values and perspectives.



Johann Wolfgang von Goethe first found fame as a writer in his 20s. But when he died at 83, he was revered as a genius—not only in literature but also in science, politics and history. His mastery was in the way he connected various topics after decades of deep observation and thinking. Draw from and connect knowledge from all fields to become a universal man/woman.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book

Mastery is attainable by anyone who's willing to work for it. Listen to your inner voice, direct your focus to observe, think deeply and practice something repeatedly until it's intuitive to you. Then, keep building on that intuition to continually move to the next level.

KEY QUOTES

"Your path to mastery is to study and absorb these details...to the point at which you feel the life force and can express it effortlessly in your work."

"[Mastery] is a power and intelligence that must be continually renewed or it will die."

This is a voluminous book that includes many detailed stories and anecdotes of Masters from all walks of life, e.g. sports, architecture, anthropology, art, business and medicine. Greene presents each idea with specific examples, deep insights and nuances to help us understand what the journey to mastery entails.

About the Author



Robert Greene (born 1959) is an American author best known for his books on strategy, power and seduction. Besides this book, he has also written several bestsellers including “The 48 Laws of Power”, “The Art of Seduction”, “The 33 Strategies of War” and “The 50th Law (with rapper 50 Cent)”.

Greene attended the University of California, Berkeley, before finishing his degree at the University of Wisconsin-Madison with a B.A. in classical studies. Before becoming an author, Greene estimates that he worked 80 jobs, including as a construction worker, translator, magazine editor, and Hollywood movie writer.

KEY QUOTES